It's almost as if his dismissal was destined to be in my hands. Or maybe not. First, he lobbed me to Misbah at mid-wicket. Dropped. Then, he plunked me to Younis at cover. Dropped. Then, Kamran Akmal pulled a Kamran Akmal, not getting anywhere near a thick edge I forced. It wasn't over: Sachin then pulled Hafeez half-heartedly to Umar Gul. Dropped.

I finally got him off Ajmal in the covers. But something was wrong that day. Or maybe everything was right in the larger scheme of things and we were part of the grand plan that would give Indian cricket its greatest moment in twenty-eight years.

For the Pakistan team, the ultimate match is always against India. Always. Regardless of where Indian cricket goes – and it's going places, no doubt – and where Pakistan cricket goes, regardless of the politics and commercial deals and whatnot, India versus Pakistan is the greatest cricket match on earth.

It's been speculated that the mental preparation that goes into a match against India is on a whole different level, that some special planning goes into each game, that the way one prepares for the match is different. All that is speculation.

The only thing which drives you in a game against India is being a Pakistani. Everything else becomes secondary – the skills, the plans. It's all about the country. I've seen it in the best players. I've seen it in myself. On game-day with India, it's all about Pakistan or bust.

2011 was our World Cup to take. We knew that if we made it past the Indians, the Lankans couldn't defeat us. I wasn't fully in charge of the team, though, and was taking on the captaincy on a tournament-by-tournament basis. My acceptability as captain was still a matter of debate – less inside, more outside the team.

There were some hiccups. I took a decision to call in Javed Miandad as batting consultant for the side. The move was aimed at providing the younger guys in the team some inspiration. It was for a motivational purpose. It wasn't meant for him to be made head coach. (Waqar Younis was.) Or a bowling coach. Or a fielding coach. Or a physio. Or a shrink, for that matter.

But he wanted to be all of that and more. Classic Javed, where the shadow is bigger than the man. He was clearly unfit for the job and our batting didn't fire when it counted the most. No doubt about it, having Javed in the squad was a disruption rather than an aid. It was my decision and a bad one.

Personally, touring India has always been my favourite thing to do on the international cricket circuit. Keep in mind that because of the shutdown of international cricket in Pakistan, we tour a lot – more than any other side – but the India tour is *the* tour. The value that cricket holds in India can't be found anywhere in the world. And the same can be said for the value of a cricketer, even a Pakistani cricketer.

An India tour is all about their people and their culture. The amount of passion, the type of fans and the level of fandom I've seen in India, I have never witnessed anything like it anywhere in the world. Cricket stars enjoy immense respect. They are considered *bhagwans*, gods. I'm not exaggerating.

As a kid, watching India versus Pakistan matches was a different thrill and invoked a unique sort of excitement. Playing against India took that very thrill, that innate anticipation that every Pakistani has, and made it into an adventure, a battle. Like good soldiers tend to do in combat, we took the lead from our seniors, from guys like Wasim Akram who, like good generals, led from the front and were themselves that much more motivated whenever we played India.